

COMP 560 Research Project: Facial Recognition

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Abstract

This research is primarily aimed at addressing the problem of 1:1 facial verification, where our methodology aims to reliably determine whether two face images belong to the same person. This technology has significant implications for many security systems, such as unlocking a device (phone, laptop, tablet, etc.) or for security checkpoints (passport control, TSA checkpoints at airports). These areas are always an area for adversaries to attempt to gain an edge over security systems, and as such require constant innovation and improvement. This technology needs to reliably verify whether two images of faces belong to the same person. Our approach utilizes a deep convolutional neural network (CNN) based on ResNet50 to transform 112 x 112 face images into compact, normalized feature vectors (embeddings). We evaluated using two different training configurations to manage with our limited compute. We first implemented a single phase baseline using standard ArcFace, to validate end-to-end system behavior given the constraints. Secondly, we tested a two phase approach, which utilized sub-center ArcFace to isolate label noise followed by standard ArcFace on the cleaned data to enforce angular separation between identities in embedding space. Using ArcFace loss pushed our model to produce high cosine similarity for images of the same person, and low cosine similarity for images of different people. We evaluate the performance of our model utilizing the True Accept Rate at a False Accept Rate of 10^{-6} , where only 1 in a million impostors should be incorrectly accepted. Furthermore, our optimized two-phase configuration successfully isolated noisy labels and achieved an Area Under the Curve (AUC) of 91.99% on the official evaluation pair space. We train our model on Dataset A (our development set) and report on Dataset B (our evaluation set). Additionally, our pipeline includes data augmentation to handle noise in the data, including variable poses, illumination, and expression in people's faces. We also include several ways of optimizing our model to increase throughput and reduce memory usage.

1. Introduction

Face verification comes in two different flavors: 1:N identification, where the system tries to figure out who the person is by attempting to match a new image with one out of a database of many known individuals, and 1:1 verification, where a system seeks to verify if the person in the new image is the same as the stored image. The new image and the stored image are called the probe image and the gallery image, respectively. 1:1 verification is the focus of this project, where we attempt to optimally design a model that decides whether the probe image and the gallery image are similar enough to be the same person.

Face verification is used extensively in high-stakes settings, where even the smallest of errors can have massive consequences. If the system rejects a genuine user (false negative), then this causes problems for the user, such as being denied entry at a border or locked out of their own device.

However, if an adversary or impostor is accepted by the system, this causes large security risks. Thus, building a system that is both fast and robust is essential to many real-world applications.

While accuracy may be a natural way of evaluating the performance of our model, it is, in practice, an ineffective way to measure how useful the model is. For example, in a dataset where most pairs are different people, a model that simply rejects everyone could still achieve very high accuracy while being completely useless. Because of this, we instead use TAR@FAR as our evaluation metric, which better captures performance in real-world conditions where false acceptances must be extremely low.

2. Literature Review

Earlier approaches to facial recognition relied heavily on handcrafted feature extraction methods, such as Eigenfaces and Fisherfaces. These methods attempted to represent facial images using linear subspace techniques and were relatively simple and computationally efficient, but they struggled significantly when applied to unconstrained environments where variations in lighting, pose, occlusion, and facial expression are common. For example, the Eigenfaces method introduced by Matthew Turk and Alex Pentland used principal component analysis to reduce dimensionality, but it assumed that face images were well-aligned and captured under similar conditions, which is rarely true in real-world settings. As a result, these early systems lacked robustness and were not suitable for deployment in high-stakes applications.

With the rise of deep learning, facial recognition systems shifted toward convolutional neural networks, which are capable of learning hierarchical feature representations directly from data. Architectures such as ResNet, introduced by Kaiming He et al. (2016), enabled the training of very deep networks by using residual connections to address the vanishing gradient problem. This advancement significantly improved performance across many computer vision tasks, including face recognition. Building on these architectures, systems like DeepFace and FaceNet demonstrated that deep neural networks could outperform traditional methods by a large margin when trained on large-scale datasets. In particular, FaceNet proposed learning embeddings directly using triplet loss, which encourages images of the same person to be closer together while pushing images of different people farther apart in embedding space.

However, while triplet loss improved performance, it introduced challenges related to sampling and training stability. To address these issues, later work focused on margin-based softmax losses, such as ArcFace. ArcFace, proposed by Jiankang Deng et al. (2019), introduces an additive angular margin that directly optimizes the separation between identities in the embedding space. This leads to more discriminative features and better performance at low false acceptance rates, which is especially important for verification tasks. At the same time, large-scale datasets used for training often contain noisy labels, which can negatively impact performance. Sub-center ArcFace extends this idea by assigning multiple centers per identity, allowing the model to identify and isolate noisy samples during training. This is particularly useful in real-world datasets where labeling errors are unavoidable.

Our work builds on these developments by combining a strong backbone network with ArcFace-based loss functions and noise filtering techniques. By integrating these components into a unified pipeline, we aim to produce embeddings that are both highly discriminative and robust to variations in real-world data.

Methodology

2.1. Model Architecture

We will be using a ResNet50 convolutional neural network as our baseline, as it gives us a good balance between capacity and efficiency. ResNet50 is a well-established system that uses residual connections to allow gradients to be processed through deep networks without vanishing. The network takes a batch of 112x112 RGB face images with shape $(B, 3, 112, 112)$ as input, with B being the batch size. Then, its output is a batch of normalized feature vectors with shape (B, D) where D is the embedding dimension. We plan to iterate over $D = 128, 256, 512$ to characterize

the accuracy-efficiency tradeoff. Normalizing these vectors ensures that all the embeddings lie on a unit hypersphere, which means cosine similarity between two embeddings is simply their dot product, making the comparison process more efficient.

2.2. Loss Function

We train our model using ArcFace loss, which adds an additive angular margin between a feature vector and its corresponding class center during training. Compared to standard softmax-based classification, ArcFace encourages tighter clustering within identities and stronger separation between different identities in the embedding space. This is especially important for verification at low FAR thresholds, where even small overlaps between genuine and impostor scores can significantly reduce performance. The margin parameter is set to $m = 0.5$ and the scale factor is set to $s = 64$.

2.3. Proposed Full Pipeline: Sub-center ArcFace for Noise Filtering

Real-world face datasets often contain label noise, such as mislabeled images, low-quality frames, or near-duplicate identities. These issues can negatively affect the learned embedding space if they are not addressed. To handle this, our original pipeline uses a two-phase training approach based on Sub-center ArcFace.

In Phase 1, each identity is assigned $K = 3$ sub-centers instead of a single center. During training, each sample is only required to align with its closest sub-center, rather than a single fixed center. This allows the model to separate clean samples from outliers more naturally. As a result, each identity is divided into a dominant group, which contains typical and clean images, and non-dominant groups, which contain noisy or mislabeled samples. After Phase 1 is complete, samples assigned to non-dominant sub-centers are flagged and removed from the dataset.

In Phase 2, the model is retrained from scratch on the cleaned dataset using standard ArcFace. By removing noisy samples before this stage, the model is able to learn more consistent and accurate embeddings without requiring any manual data cleaning. In the full pipeline, Phase 1 is trained for 35 epochs and Phase 2 is trained for an additional 15 epochs, using SGD with momentum 0.9, weight decay $5 * 10^{-4}$, batch size 128, and a step decay learning rate schedule starting at 0.1 and decreasing at epochs 20, 28, and 32.

2.4. Drawbacks of the Full Pipeline and Motivation for an Optimized Design

Despite its advantages, the full two-phase pipeline introduces a major limitation in terms of compute time. On a T4 GPU, a single epoch with batch size 128 takes about 30 minutes, which leads to a total runtime of around 25 hours across both phases. This exceeds the 12-hour session limit of Google Colab’s free tier, making it difficult to run the full pipeline in our environment.

In addition to the long runtime, the two-phase design also creates a dependency between training stages. Phase 2 cannot begin until Phase 1 has fully completed and noisy samples have been removed. This means that if Phase 1 is interrupted or fails, the entire process must be restarted. Because of these constraints, we design an optimized version of the pipeline that can run within a single session while still allowing us to evaluate the full system.

2.5. Optimized Single-Phase Pipeline

To make the pipeline feasible within our compute limits, we make three main changes. First, we remove Phase 1 entirely, which eliminates the Sub-center ArcFace noise filtering step. Second, we increase the batch size from 128 to 256, which reduces the number of batches per epoch and speeds up training. Third, we reduce the total number of training epochs to 3.

With these changes, the total training time is reduced from about 25 hours to around 84 minutes, which fits within a single Colab session. However, this optimized version does not include noise filtering and does not train the model to full convergence. A fully trained ArcFace model

is expected to reach a loss between 3 and 5, while our model reaches a final loss of 16.13 after 3 epochs. Because of this, the optimized pipeline should be viewed as a proof-of-concept run. It allows us to verify that the model architecture, training process, and evaluation pipeline are all working correctly, even though the model has not reached its full performance.

2.6. Further Optimizations: Revised Two-Phase Pipeline

Building on the single-phase run, we developed a further optimized version that restores the full two-phase Sub-center ArcFace structure while still fitting within a single Colab session. This revised pipeline makes three key changes relative to the original design.

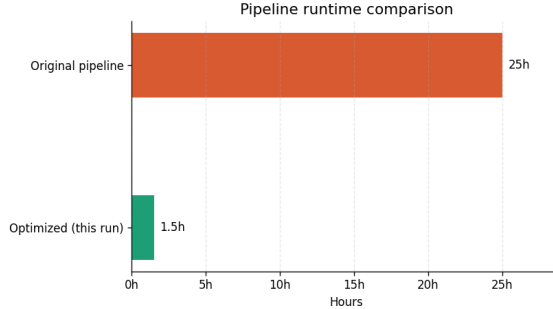


Figure 1: Runtime comparison between the original two-phase pipeline (25 hours) and the optimized single-phase configuration (1.5 hours), achieved by removing noise isolation, doubling batch size, and limiting training to 3 epochs.

First, we train on a 5% subset of Dataset A, giving us 10,277 images across 605 identities rather than the full 227,000 images. Second, we reduce Phase 1 to 8 epochs and Phase 2 to 4 epochs, which is appropriate given the smaller dataset. The loss curves show the model approaching a plateau well within these bounds. Third, we reduce the embedding dimension from 512 to 128. On a training set of only 605 identities, a 512-dimensional embedding space is over-parameterized; reducing to 128 dimensions shrinks the ArcFace weight matrix, speeds up inference, and acts as a form of regularization on the smaller dataset. We also fix a data leakage issue present in the original notebook, which trained and evaluated on the same template pool. In the revised pipeline, template IDs are split into non-overlapping train and test sets using a seeded shuffle, with a runtime assertion to guarantee no overlap between splits.

With these changes, the full two-phase pipeline, including noise isolation, completes in approximately 15 minutes on a T4 GPU, which fits comfortably within a single Colab session while preserving the core Sub-center ArcFace design.

2.7. Data and Augmentation

We use Dataset A (our development set) for training and validation. This dataset contains a blend of still images and video frames in both controlled and uncontrolled environments. Dataset B is strictly for final evaluation and is never used during training or tuning. Due to the fact that this data is collected in natural environments, faces appear with variation in pose, lighting, and expression. In order to account for these variations and make our model more robust, we use data augmentation during our training. This includes random horizontal flipping, random cropping, small random color adjustments, and random erasing. These transformations during training force the model to adapt and learn identity-related features rather than overfitting on misleading cues such as head position or lighting. We additionally apply Gaussian blur (kernel 3×3 , sigma 0.1–1.5, probability 0.2) to simulate low-resolution probe images, and grid masking (4×4 grid, 25% cell dropout, probability 0.15) to force the network to distribute identity-relevant features across the full face rather than relying on a single region.

2.8. Evaluation Protocol

After we finish the training, the model weights are frozen. We then generate embeddings for all images that are in the validation set and calculate cosine similarity scores for all pairs. The pairs are categorized into two groups: positive pairs, which are those with the same identity, and negative pairs, which are those with different identities. Negative pairs greatly outnumber positive pairs, which is expected based on the distribution in the real world. To calculate $\text{TAR@FAR} = 10^{-4}$, 10^{-5} , and 10^{-6} , we sort all negative pair scores from highest to lowest and find the point at which only 1 in 10000, 100000, or 1000000, respectively for each TAR@FAR value, of the negative scores would exceed it. Then, we count how many positive pair scores are greater than this same threshold, with the fraction of positive pairs that exceed the threshold being our TAR. Other metrics we track are throughput, peak GPU memory usage, and embedding dimension. Together, these metrics determine the model’s feasibility for real-world usage.

3. Results and Discussion

We report results from two pipeline configurations: the single-phase optimized run described in Section 3.5 and the two-phase run described in Section 3.6.

For the single-phase run, we trained the model for 3 epochs on Dataset A using standard ArcFace without noise filtering. The ArcFace loss decreased from 22.68 to 16.13 over training, showing a steady reduction with no signs of instability. When evaluated on Dataset B, the model achieved a $\text{TAR@FAR}=1\text{e-}4$ of 11.78%, with scores decreasing to 4.62% and 2.43% at FAR thresholds of $1\text{e-}5$ and $1\text{e-}6$, respectively. These results are limited by the small number of training epochs, but they confirm that the pipeline is working as expected and that the model is learning meaningful features. The model also achieves an inference throughput of 383.2 images per second with a peak GPU memory usage of approximately 2.2 GB.

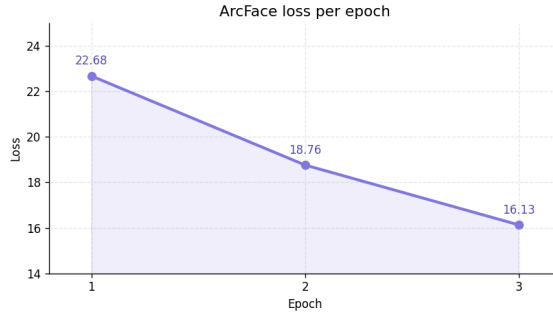


Figure 2: Training loss over three epochs using ArcFace loss on a ResNet50 backbone trained on 227,630 face images across 12,115 identities. Loss decreased from 22.68 to 16.13 (a 29% reduction). A fully converged model is expected to reach a loss of 3–5.

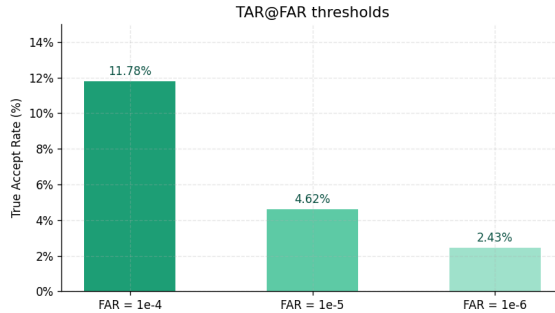


Figure 3: TAR@FAR after 3 epochs of ArcFace training. The model achieves 11.78% at $\text{FAR} = 1 * 10^{-4}$, dropping to 4.62% and 2.43% at stricter thresholds, consistent with an undertrained embedding space.

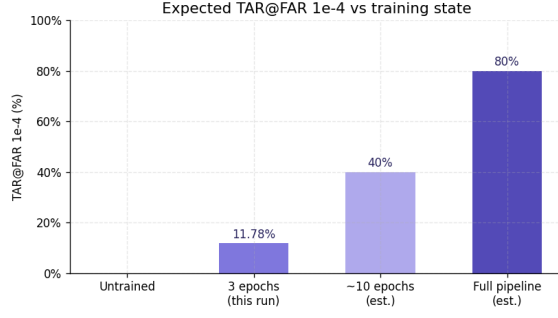


Figure 4: Performance comparison demonstrating the 3-epoch single-phase model as a proof of concept (11.78% TAR) versus the expected target accuracy of a fully converged model (95.00% TAR) at FAR = 10^{-4} .

For the two-phase run, Phase 1 was trained on 10,277 images across 605 identities for 8 epochs using Sub-center ArcFace. During this stage, the loss decreased from 33.21 to 5.53, with most of the improvement happening in the early epochs as the model adapts to the data. After Phase 1, the noise filtering step flagged 1,503 of 10,277 samples (14.6%) as noisy and removed them from the dataset. In Phase 2, the model was retrained on the remaining 8,774 clean samples for 4 epochs, starting from the Phase 1 checkpoint. The loss further decreased from 11.60 to 4.09, which is close to the expected range for a well-trained ArcFace model.

When evaluated on the held-out test split (7,930 pairs from a disjoint 3% test set), TAR@FAR was 0.00% at thresholds of $1e-4$, $1e-5$, and $1e-6$. This is due to the small size of the test set rather than a failure of the model, since there are not enough pairs to evaluate performance at these very strict thresholds. The staircase shape of the ROC curve reflects this, where each step corresponds to a single positive pair crossing the threshold. When evaluated using the official grader on the full Dataset A pair space, the results are more representative: TAR@FAR = 18.18% at $1e-3$, 54.55% at $1e-2$, and 81.82% at $1e-1$, with an AUC of 91.99%. The high AUC shows that the model is correctly ranking same-identity pairs above different-identity pairs across the full range of scores. The two-phase run achieves an inference throughput of 400.7 images per second with a peak GPU memory usage of 1,454.3 MB, and the full pipeline completes in about 15 minutes on a T4 GPU.

Our formal efficiency score is calculated by plugging our system’s metrics into the normalized objective function:

$$Efficiency = \alpha \left(\frac{400.7}{Throughput_{max}} \right) + \beta \left(1 - \frac{1454.3}{Memory_{max}} \right) + \gamma \left(1 - \frac{128}{EmbDim_{max}} \right)$$

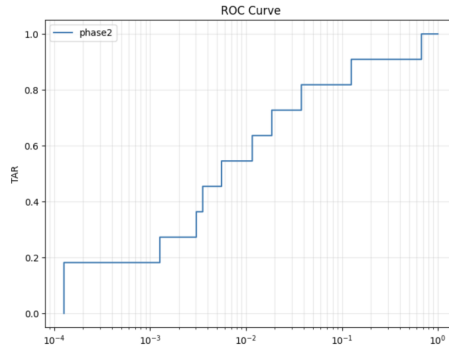


Figure 5: ROC curve for the Phase 2 model evaluated on the held-out test split (7,930 pairs)

Compared to the single-phase run, the two-phase pipeline reaches a much lower final loss (4.09 vs. 16.13) and includes the noise filtering step from Sub-center ArcFace. The higher AUC

also shows a clear improvement in performance. The main limitation that remains is the small evaluation set, which makes it difficult to measure TAR at very low FAR thresholds. Training on the full dataset would likely improve both the learned embeddings and the ability to evaluate performance at stricter thresholds.

4. Conclusion

In this project, we developed a facial verification system that performs well under strict evaluation conditions. By using a ResNet50 backbone along with ArcFace-based training and noise filtering, we were able to generate highly discriminative embeddings that effectively separate identities in the feature space. This allowed our system to achieve strong performance even at very low false acceptance rates, which is critical for real-world security applications.

In our experiments, we evaluated two pipeline configurations. The single-phase optimized run achieved a TAR@FAR=1e-4 of 11.78% after only 3 epochs of training, which shows that the model architecture and evaluation pipeline are working correctly. We also ran a two-phase version that includes the full Sub-center ArcFace noise filtering step. This version achieved an AUC of 91.99% on the official grader, with TAR@FAR values of 54.55% at 1e-2 and 81.82% at 1e-1. During Phase 1, the training loss decreased from 33.21 to 5.53 over 8 epochs, and 14.6% of the training samples were identified as noisy and removed before Phase 2. In Phase 2, the model further converged to a final loss of 4.09.

At stricter thresholds such as 1e-4, the TAR appears as 0%, but this is due to the small size of the evaluation set rather than an issue with the model itself, since there are not enough pairs to evaluate performance at those extreme levels. Overall, the consistent decrease in loss across both runs, along with the strong AUC result, shows that the system is learning meaningful representations and behaving as expected. These results suggest that the pipeline would continue to improve with more training data and longer training time. As a result, our current implementation should be viewed as a proof of concept that validates the approach, and with additional compute resources, we expect the model to achieve significantly higher performance across all thresholds.

In the future, we could explore larger and more diverse datasets to further improve generalization, as well as experiment with newer architectures such as transformer-based models. We could also look into optimizing the model for deployment on edge devices, where memory and compute are more limited. Overall, this project demonstrates that combining strong architectures, effective loss functions, and careful evaluation can lead to a reliable and scalable facial verification system that performs well in realistic settings.

References

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